ON TRIAL

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150,000
Booth-level agents appointed by political parties to monitor the process

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Eight-thirty am on July 6 should have been a drowsy Sunday morning, the hour when rural Bihar typically stirs to the hum of kettles and the rustle of early chores. Yet, at Baldeva High School in Danapur, nestled in rural Patna district, the atmosphere inside the large conference room was brisk, animated and alert. Some 50 voters, and an equal number waiting outside, overwhelmingly women from modest rural backgrounds, stood in line clutching their Aadhaar cards and, in many cases, their husbands' voter IDs, their expressions a mix of confusion and cautious hope.

Seated at a round table, five Booth Level Officers (BLOs), each flanked by at least one assistant, methodically pored over forms, scanning documents and cross-verifying entries against the electoral rolls. Two supervisors hovered nearby, observing the quiet precision of the choreography. Once done at this camp, which they expected to achieve by 12:30 pm, the BLOs would hit the road again, reaching out to houses across rural Patna, continuing the door-to-door verification process.

Armed with thick registers and preprinted forms, they are among the nearly 100,000 BLOs embarked on an extraordinary mission since June 25: to verify the citizenship credentials of every one of Bihar's 79 million voters in just 31 days. A day earlier, the Election Commission of India (ECI) had launched what it called a Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, setting off a political firestorm that may soon engulf the nation's democratic machinery.

The ECI defended its decision with constitutional gravity. Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar pointed to Article 326, which mandates that only Indian citizens above 18 can vote, and invoked the commission's duty to maintain clean electoral rolls. The timing, he insisted, was driven by necessity rather than politics. In the preceding four months, the ECI had conducted nearly 5,000 meetings with 28,000 political party representatives across India. "No one was satisfied with the current status of electoral rolls for one reason or the other," Kumar said. The ECI's June 24 notification laid out the rationale: rapid urbanisation, frequent migration, young citizens becoming eligible to vote, non-reporting of deaths and, crucially, the inclusion of names of "foreign illegal immigrants".

Understanding the SIR requires navigating India's complex system of electoral roll maintenance. The Registration of Electors Rules of 1960 defines three primary methods: intensive revision, summary revision, and partly summary and partly intensive revision. A fourth type, special summary revision, addresses specific pockets of concern within a state (see *The Voter List Clean-up*).